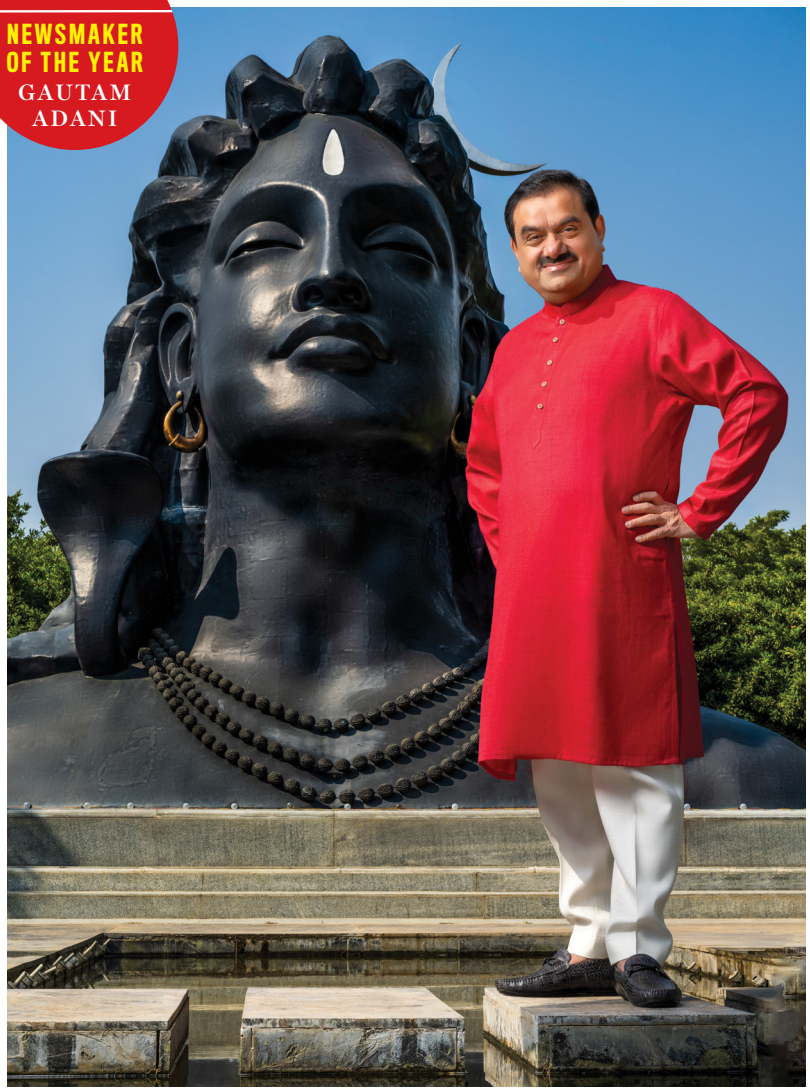




Gautam Adani standing next to the Adiyogi Shiva statue at his residence in Ahmedabad

THE TURNING POINTS

It's his learn-by-earning model and faith in his own intuition that would propel Gautam to greater heights. The seventh of eight children, he grew up in Ahmedabad where his father, Shantilal Adani, was a textiles and commodity trader. But while Gautam was good at studies, he dropped out after passing his tenth class and decided to head to Mumbai (travelling in third class by train) to be a diamond trader. His logic was that his elder brothers had gone on to do higher studies but they still returned to work in the family business. Adani's first big break as an entrepreneur would come when his elder brother bought a plastics factory in Ahmedabad and asked him to return to help run it. Gautam soon found that the raw material shortage was acute, not just for his brother's factory but for thousands of other small-scale manufacturers. So, when Rajiv Gandhi as prime minister liberalised the export-import policy in 1985, he seized the opportunity and began importing raw materials and supplying them to factories at a profit.

The second big turning point would come in 1991, when the Narasimha Rao government ended the licence raj, ushering in liberalisation and opening up infrastructure development to public-private partnerships. With

Adani aligns his business vision with that of the priorities of the government. That gives him the tailwind to succeed